

COLOURING THE p -ADIC PLANE

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ABSTRACT. Let $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_p^2)$ be the chromatic number of the graph on $\mathbb{Q}_p^2$ in which (x, y) and (x', y') are adjacent when $(x - x')^2 + (y - y')^2 = 1$. Bardestani and Mallahi-Karai showed that its Borel chromatic number is finite exactly when $p = 2$ or $p \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$, and asked whether it is bounded independently of p . It is not: for $p \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$ every proper colouring with Haar-measurable colour classes uses at least $1 + (p + 1)/(2\sqrt{p})$ colours. The proof is the Delsarte–Hoffman bound on the compact group $\mathbb{Z}_p^2$, where the Fourier coefficients of the unit circle are Kloosterman sums at the first level and at most $2/(p + 1)$ at every deeper level. We also show $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_7^2) = 4$, for ordinary and for Borel colourings, while $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_2^2) = 2$ and $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_3^2) = 3$ follow from results of Madore. A theorem of Davies shows that the graph of every non-degenerate isotropic form over a field of characteristic 0 has infinite chromatic number, so the dichotomy of Bardestani and Mallahi-Karai holds for ordinary colourings too; in particular $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_p^2) = \infty$ for $p \equiv 1 \pmod{4}$. Finally, unit-distance graphs over 27 real quadratic fields give $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_p^2) \geq 4$ for every prime $p \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$ with $7 \leq p < 2\,129\,503\,819$, and a Chebotarev argument shows that no finite set of number fields gives this bound for every such p . In every dimension n we determine when $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_p^n)$ is finite, and show $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_2^4) = 4$ through the residue field $\mathbb{F}_4$ of the 2-adic quaternions.

1. INTRODUCTION

For a field F let $G(F)$ be the graph on F^2 in which v and w are adjacent when $Q(v - w) = 1$, with $Q(x, y) = x^2 + y^2$, and write $\chi(F^2)$ for its chromatic number. For $F = \mathbb{R}$ this is the Hadwiger–Nelson problem, and $5 \leq \chi(\mathbb{R}^2) \leq 7$: the lower bound is due to de Grey [7] and to Exoo and Ismailescu [8], the upper bound to Isbell (see [21]). Woodall showed $\chi(\mathbb{Q}^2) = 2$ [25], and the planes over number fields have been studied by Johnson [12], Fischer [9], Madore [13], Moorhouse [17] and others. Madore observed that reduction modulo a prime gives $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_p^2) \leq \chi(\mathbb{F}_p^2)$ for $p \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$ [13, ¶1.5 and Remark 3.6].

Bardestani and Mallahi-Karai [3] studied the graphs of quadratic forms over local fields. For a local field F of characteristic 0 they proved that the *Borel* chromatic number of the graph of a non-degenerate form is infinite if and only if the form is isotropic, using the spectral bound of Bachoc, DeCorte, Oliveira and Vallentin [2]. Over $\mathbb{Q}_p$ the form $x^2 + y^2$ is anisotropic exactly when -1 is not a square, that is for $p = 2$ and $p \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$. For $p \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$ they noted that the Borel chromatic number $\chi_B(\mathbb{Q}_p^2)$ is $O(p^2)$, and asked:

Question ([3, Question 1], the p -adic Hadwiger–Nelson problem). Is there a constant B with $\chi_B(\mathbb{Q}_p^2) \leq B$ for every prime $p \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$?

Write χ_m for the measurable chromatic number (colour classes measurable for the Haar measure), so that $\chi \leq \chi_m \leq \chi_B$. Our first result answers the question in the negative. We have not found another answer in the literature, including the later papers of the same authors [4, 5].

Theorem 1. *For every prime $p \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$,*

$$1 + \frac{p + 1}{2\sqrt{p}} \leq \chi_m(\mathbb{Q}_p^2) \leq \chi_B(\mathbb{Q}_p^2) \leq \chi(\mathbb{F}_p^2),$$

Date: Draft, 2 October 2026.

2020 Mathematics Subject Classification. Primary 05C15; Secondary 11S80, 11L05, 05C63, 52C10.

Key words and phrases. Hadwiger–Nelson problem, p -adic numbers, unit-distance graph, Borel chromatic number, measurable chromatic number, Kloosterman sums.

These results were obtained with the assistance of an AI system (Claude, by Anthropic), which carried out the computations and the checks, and helped to draft this note. No mathematician has checked the note yet. The author is not a professional mathematician and submits it for independent verification.

and $\chi(\mathbb{F}_p^2) \leq (p+1)/2$ for $p > 3$. In particular $\chi_B(\mathbb{Q}_p^2) \rightarrow \infty$.

Here $\mathbb{F}_p^2$ denotes the graph $G(\mathbb{F}_p)$. Le Anh Vinh [22, Theorem 1] showed $(\frac{1}{2} + o(1))\sqrt{q} \leq \chi(\mathbb{F}_q^2) \leq (q + q/r)/2$ for powers $q > 3$ of an odd prime r ; the upper bound in Theorem 1 is his. The lower bound of Theorem 1 has the same leading term as his, but it holds for all measurable colourings of the p -adic plane, not only for those that factor through $\mathbb{F}_p^2$. The exact Fourier coefficients give better values for small p (Table 1): at least 5 colours from $p = 23$, 6 for $p = 59$ and every $p \geq 67$, 7 for $p = 71$ and every $p \geq 103$.

For the ordinary chromatic number:

Theorem 2. $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_7^2) = \chi_B(\mathbb{Q}_7^2) = 4$. Moreover $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_2^2) = \chi_B(\mathbb{Q}_2^2) = 2$ and $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_3^2) = \chi_B(\mathbb{Q}_3^2) = 3$.

The upper bounds are Madore's reductions [13, Propositions 3.2 and 3.8], which give locally constant colourings, and the values 2 and 3 follow at once from his results (his 9-cycle over $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{7})$ [13, Proposition 4.3] lies in $\mathbb{Q}_3^2$). The new value is $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_7^2) = 4$. Since 3 is not a square modulo 7, the plane $\mathbb{Q}_7^2$ contains no unit equilateral triangle (the third vertex of a unit triangle on 0 and (a, b) is $(\frac{a}{2} - \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}b, \frac{b}{2} + \frac{\sqrt{3}}{2}a)$, which forces $\sqrt{3}$ into the field), so the classical 4-chromatic graphs, built from triangles, do not embed; we use a triangle-free 76-vertex graph over $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{11})$ with no proper 3-colouring [11], as $11 \equiv 2^2 \pmod{7}$. The three ordinary values are also proved in Lean 4 with Mathlib [15, 14], in `lean/PadicPlanes.lean` of [10]; for instance `(QuadraticPlanes.sumSqGraph Q_7).chromaticNumber = 4`.

In the isotropic case the ordinary chromatic number is infinite as well, by a theorem of Davies [6]:

Proposition 3. *Let F be a field of characteristic 0 and Q a non-degenerate isotropic quadratic form on F^n , $n \geq 2$. Then the graph on F^n in which v, w are adjacent when $Q(v - w) = 1$ has infinite chromatic number. In particular $\chi(F^2) = \infty$ when -1 is a square in F , and $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_p^2) = \infty$ for $p \equiv 1 \pmod{4}$.*

Corollary 4. *Let F be a local field of characteristic 0 and Q a non-degenerate quadratic form in at least two variables over F . Then the chromatic number of its graph is finite if and only if Q is anisotropic, if and only if its Borel chromatic number is finite. In particular $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_p^2)$ is finite exactly when $p = 2$ or $p \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$.*

Proof. If Q is anisotropic, [3, Theorem 1.1] gives $\chi \leq \chi_B < \infty$; if it is isotropic, Proposition 3 gives $\chi_B \geq \chi = \infty$. $\square$

In all dimensions (Proposition 11 in §6), $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_p^n)$ is finite exactly when $n = 1$, or $n = 2$ and $p \not\equiv 1 \pmod{4}$, or $p = 2$ and $n \leq 4$; $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_2^4) = 4$, and $\chi_B(\mathbb{Q}_p^1) = 3 > \chi(\mathbb{Q}_p^1)$ for odd p .

Finally, every number field K with an embedding $K \hookrightarrow \mathbb{Q}_p$ gives $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_p^2) \geq \chi(K^2)$. Unit-distance graphs with no proper 3-colouring over 27 real quadratic fields [11] give:

Theorem 5. $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_p^2) \geq 4$ for every prime $p \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$ with $7 \leq p < 2\,129\,503\,819$. Moreover $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_{83}^2) \geq 5$.

No finite set of number fields can do this for every p :

Proposition 6. *Let $\mathcal{K}$ be a finite set of number fields with $\chi(K^2) \geq 4$ for every $K \in \mathcal{K}$. Then there are infinitely many primes $p \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$ such that no $K \in \mathcal{K}$ embeds in $\mathbb{Q}_p$.*

For the 27 fields of Theorem 5 the first such prime after 3 is 2 129 503 819. Below $3 \cdot 10^{10}$ there are seventeen, 3 included (the next is 3 502 762 979), where the density 2^{-25} given by Chebotarev's theorem predicts about 19: the 27 values of d span a subgroup of rank 25 of $\mathbb{Q}^\times/\mathbb{Q}^{\times 2}$, with relations $11 \cdot 35 \cdot 119 \cdot 935 = 6545^2$ and $35 \cdot 47 \cdot 455 \cdot 611 = 21385^2$ of four factors each. The proposition is about graphs over fixed fields; a single abstract graph might be realised in $\mathbb{Q}_p^2$ over different fields for different p .

2. REDUCTION MODULO p : UPPER BOUNDS

Lemma 7 (Madore [13, Propositions 3.2 and 3.8]). *Let $p = 2$ or $p \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$. If $x, y \in \mathbb{Q}_p$ and $x^2 + y^2 = 1$, then $x, y \in \mathbb{Z}_p$, and $(x, y) \bmod p$ is a nonzero point of the circle $C_p = \{(a, b) \in \mathbb{F}_p^2 : a^2 + b^2 = 1\}$.*

Proof. Suppose $-k = \min(v_p(x), v_p(y)) < 0$. If only one of x, y had valuation $-k$, then $v_p(x^2 + y^2) = -2k \neq 0$. So $x = p^{-k}a$, $y = p^{-k}b$ with $a, b \in \mathbb{Z}_p^\times$ and $a^2 + b^2 = p^{2k}$. For odd p this gives $(a/b)^2 \equiv -1 \pmod{p}$, impossible for $p \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$. For $p = 2$, odd squares are $1 \bmod 8$, so $v_2(a^2 + b^2) = 1$, while $v_2(p^{2k})$ is even. Hence $x, y \in \mathbb{Z}_p$, and reducing $x^2 + y^2 = 1$ gives the rest. $\square$

Proposition 8 (cf. [13, Remark 3.6]). *If $p = 2$ or $p \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$, then $\chi_B(\mathbb{Q}_p^2) \leq \chi(\mathbb{F}_p^2)$, by a locally constant colouring.*

Proof. Let $r(v)$ be the representative of $v + \mathbb{Z}_p^2$ whose coordinates are sums $\sum_{j < 0} a_j p^j$ with $0 \leq a_j < p$; it is locally constant. Given a proper colouring κ of $\mathbb{F}_p^2$, put $c(v) = \kappa((v - r(v)) \bmod p)$. If v and w are adjacent, $v - w \in \mathbb{Z}_p^2$ by Lemma 7, so $r(v) = r(w)$, and $(v - r(v)) - (w - r(w)) = v - w$ reduces to a point of C_p ; hence $c(v) \neq c(w)$. The colouring is locally constant, so it is Borel. $\square$

For $p = 2$, $C_2 = \{(1, 0), (0, 1)\}$ and $\kappa(a, b) = a + b$ is a proper 2-colouring; for $p = 3$, $C_3 = \{(\pm 1, 0), (0, \pm 1)\}$ and $\kappa(a, b) = a + b \bmod 3$ is a proper 3-colouring. For $p = 7$ the graph $\mathbb{F}_7^2$ is 4-colourable (Moorhouse [17], Vinh [22]; a colouring is stored in [10]).

3. MEASURABLE COLOURINGS: PROOF OF THEOREM 1

The following lemma is the ratio bound of Bachoc, DeCorte, Oliveira and Vallentin [2], which [3, Theorem 2.5] states on $\mathbb{Q}_p^n$; we include the short proof for completeness. The new input is Lemma 10.

Lemma 9 (Delsarte–Hoffman on a compact group). *Let Γ be a compact abelian group with Haar probability measure μ , and σ a probability measure on a closed set $S \subset \Gamma$ with $S = -S$, $0 \notin S$ and σ invariant under $s \mapsto -s$. For a character ψ of Γ put $\hat{\sigma}(\psi) = \int \psi d\sigma$, which is real, and let $m = \inf\{\hat{\sigma}(\psi) : \psi \neq 1\}$, the infimum over the nontrivial characters; suppose $m < 0$. If $A \subset \Gamma$ is measurable and $A \cap (A + s) = \emptyset$ for every $s \in S$, then $\mu(A) \leq -m/(1 - m)$.*

Proof. The function $f(x) = \mu(A \cap (A - x))$ is continuous and positive definite, with $\hat{f}(\psi) = |\hat{1}_A(\psi)|^2 \geq 0$, $\hat{f}(1) = \mu(A)^2$ and $\sum_\psi \hat{f}(\psi) = \|1_A\|_2^2 = \mu(A)$ (Parseval); so $f = \sum_\psi \hat{f}(\psi)\psi$ uniformly. By hypothesis $f = 0$ on S , hence

$$0 = \int f d\sigma = \sum_\psi \hat{f}(\psi) \hat{\sigma}(\psi) \geq \mu(A)^2 + m(\mu(A) - \mu(A)^2),$$

which gives the bound. $\square$

Let $p \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$. Identify $\mathbb{Z}_p^2$ with the ring $\mathcal{O} = \mathbb{Z}_p[i]$ of integers of the unramified quadratic extension $E = \mathbb{Q}_p(i)$ by $(x, y) \mapsto x + iy$; then Q becomes the norm $Nz = z\bar{z}$, and the unit circle is the compact group $S = \{z \in \mathcal{O} : Nz = 1\}$, with its Haar probability measure σ . Since $E/\mathbb{Q}_p$ is unramified and p is odd, the norm maps $\mathcal{O}^\times$ onto $\mathbb{Z}_p^\times$ and $1 + p^r \mathcal{O}$ onto $1 + p^r \mathbb{Z}_p$ for every $r \geq 1$; so the image of S in $(\mathcal{O}/p^r)^\times$ is the whole norm-one subgroup, of order $(p + 1)p^{r-1}$, and the classes of S modulo p^r all have measure $1/((p + 1)p^{r-1})$. Write $e(t) = \exp(2\pi it)$ and $e_p(t) = e(\{t\}_p)$ for $t \in \mathbb{Q}_p$. The characters of $\mathcal{O}$ are $\psi_\xi(z) = e_p(\text{Tr}(\xi z))$ for $\xi \in E/\mathcal{O}$ (the different of $E/\mathbb{Q}_p$ is trivial), the trivial one being $\xi = 0$; call $\ell = -v_p(\xi)$ the *level* of ψ_ξ . Since $-1 \in S$ and $\bar{S} = S$, every $\hat{\sigma}(\xi) = \int_S \psi_\xi d\sigma$ is real.

Lemma 10. *Let $\xi = p^{-\ell} \xi_0$ with $\xi_0 \in \mathcal{O}^\times$.*

- (1) *If $\ell = 1$, then $\hat{\sigma}(\xi) = \lambda/(p + 1)$, where λ is an eigenvalue of the graph $\mathbb{F}_p^2$; more precisely $\lambda = -K(n)$ with $n = N \xi_0 \bmod p$ and the Kloosterman sum $K(n) = \sum_{x \in \mathbb{F}_p^\times} e((x + n/x)/p)$, so $|\lambda| \leq 2\sqrt{p}$.*

(2) If $\ell \geq 2$, then $|\hat{\sigma}(\xi)| \leq 2/((p+1)p^{\lfloor \ell/2 \rfloor - 1}) \leq 2/(p+1)$.

Proof. (1) The character factors through $\mathcal{O}/p\mathcal{O} = \mathbb{F}_{p^2}$, and S maps onto the norm-one group $\bar{C} = \{z \in \mathbb{F}_{p^2} : z\bar{z} = 1\}$, of order $p+1$, with fibres of equal measure. So $\hat{\sigma}(\xi) = \frac{1}{p+1} \sum_{z \in \bar{C}} \psi(\text{Tr}(cz))$ with $c = \xi_0 \bmod p$ and $\psi(t) = e(t/p)$, the eigenvalue of $\mathbb{F}_p^2$ at the corresponding character. That these eigenvalues are Kloosterman sums is due to Medrano, Myers, Stark and Terras [16]; here is the short argument. With $n = Nc \neq 0$, $w = cz$ gives $\sum_{z \in \bar{C}} \psi(\text{Tr}(cz)) = \sum_{Nw=n} \psi(\text{Tr } w)$. An element w with $Nw = n$ and $\text{Tr } w = t$ is a root of $X^2 - tX + n$, and conversely each root outside $\mathbb{F}_p$ has this norm and trace, while a root $w \in \mathbb{F}_p$ has norm w^2 and trace $2w$, which fits only when $t^2 = 4n$. So there are $1 - \eta(t^2 - 4n)$ such w , where η is the quadratic character of $\mathbb{F}_p$. Similarly $x + n/x = t$ has $1 + \eta(t^2 - 4n)$ solutions $x \in \mathbb{F}_p^\times$. As $\sum_t \psi(t) = 0$, the first sum is $-\sum_t \psi(t)\eta(t^2 - 4n) = -K(n)$, and Weil's bound [24] gives $|K(n)| \leq 2\sqrt{p}$.

(2) Let $j = \lceil \ell/2 \rceil$, $r = \ell - j = \lfloor \ell/2 \rfloor \geq 1$, and $S_j = \{s \in S : s \equiv 1 \bmod p^j\}$. For $s_0 \in S$, the function $s \mapsto \psi_\xi(s_0 s) / \psi_\xi(s_0) = e_p(\text{Tr}(\xi s_0(s - 1)))$ is a character of S_j , because $(1 + p^j t)(1 + p^j t') = 1 + p^j(t + t') + p^{2j}tt'$ and $v_p(\xi p^{2j}) \geq 0$. Its average over S_j is 0 unless it is trivial. The elements $(1 + p^j ia/2)/(1 - p^j ia/2)$, $a \in \mathbb{Z}_p$, lie in S_j and are $\equiv 1 + p^j ia \pmod{p^{2j}}$, so triviality forces $e_p(\text{Tr}(i p^{j-\ell} a \xi_0 s_0)) = 1$ for all $a \in \mathbb{Z}_p$, that is, $\text{Tr}(i \xi_0 s_0) = -2 \text{Im}(\xi_0 s_0) \equiv 0 \pmod{p^r}$. Then $\xi_0 s_0 \equiv u \pmod{p^r}$ for some $u \in \mathbb{Z}_p$ with $u^2 \equiv N \xi_0 \pmod{p^r}$, so s_0 lies in one of at most two classes modulo p^r , each of measure $1/((p+1)p^{r-1})$; and the cosets of S_j refine these classes since $j \geq r$. Averaging over the cosets of S_j first gives the bound. $\square$

Proof of Theorem 1. The upper bounds are Proposition 8 and [22, Theorem 1]. For the lower bound, let c be a proper colouring of $\mathbb{Q}_p^2$ with k measurable classes. Their traces on $\mathbb{Z}_p^2$ cover it, so one of them, A , has $\mu(A) \geq 1/k$, and since $S \subset \mathbb{Z}_p^2$ no two points of A differ by an element of S . By Lemma 10, $m \geq -\max(2\sqrt{p}, 2)/(p+1) = -2\sqrt{p}/(p+1)$, and $m < 0$ because the eigenvalues of $\mathbb{F}_p^2$ sum to 0; so Lemma 9 gives $1/k \leq \mu(A) \leq |m|/(1 + |m|)$, that is, $k \geq 1 + 1/|m| \geq 1 + (p+1)/(2\sqrt{p})$. $\square$

With the exact least eigenvalue $\lambda_{\min}$ of $\mathbb{F}_p^2$, the same proof gives $\chi_m(\mathbb{Q}_p^2) \geq 1 + (p+1)/\max(|\lambda_{\min}|, 2)$. We computed $\lambda_{\min}$ in interval arithmetic (`padic_measurable.py` in [10]); Table 1 shows the result. Weil's bound alone gives at least 6 colours for $p \geq 62$, 7 for $p \geq 98$, 8 for $p \geq 142$ and 9 for $p \geq 194$; with the exact spectra (computed for $p < 200$), $\chi_m(\mathbb{Q}_p^2) \geq 6$ already for $p = 59$, ≥ 7 for $p = 71$, ≥ 8 for every $p \geq 131$, and ≥ 9 for $p = 191$.

p	$\lambda_{\min}$	$1 + 1/ m $	$\chi_m(\mathbb{Q}_p^2) \geq$
3	-2.0000	3.0000	3
7	-4.4940	2.7802	3
11	-4.7958	3.5022	4
19	-7.6097	3.6282	4
23	-7.9607	4.0148	5
31	-10.6665	4.000044	5
43	-11.9622	4.6782	5
47	-12.8465	4.7364	5
59	-14.9176	5.0221	6
67	-15.0567	5.5163	6
71	-14.1728	6.0801	7
79	-17.1019	5.6778	6
83	-17.7087	5.7434	6
103	-20.0322	6.1916	7
107	-19.0495	6.6694	7

TABLE 1. Lower bounds for the measurable chromatic number of $\mathbb{Q}_p^2$, $p \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$, from the least eigenvalue of $\mathbb{F}_p^2$ (rounded; the bounds are rigorous lower ends of 120-bit intervals).

Together with Theorem 2, $\chi_m(\mathbb{Q}_p^2) = \chi_B(\mathbb{Q}_p^2) = \chi(\mathbb{Q}_p^2)$ for $p = 2, 3, 7$, while $4 \leq \chi_m(\mathbb{Q}_p^2) \leq \chi_B(\mathbb{Q}_p^2) \leq 5$ for $p = 11, 19$, where $\chi(\mathbb{F}_p^2) = 5$ ([10] stores 5-colourings of $\mathbb{F}_{11}^2$ and $\mathbb{F}_{19}^2$, and certificates that 4 colours do not suffice).

4. LOWER BOUNDS FROM NUMBER FIELDS

If K is a field and $\iota : K \hookrightarrow \mathbb{Q}_p$, then $(x, y) \mapsto (\iota x, \iota y)$ is an injective homomorphism $G(K) \rightarrow G(\mathbb{Q}_p)$, so $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_p^2) \geq \chi(K^2)$. For odd p and $p \nmid d$, Hensel's lemma gives $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{d}) \subset \mathbb{Q}_p$ exactly when d is a square modulo p .

Proof of Theorem 2. The upper bounds are Proposition 8. The graph has edges, so $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_2^2) \geq 2$. For $p = 3$, besides Madore's 9-cycle, the unit vectors

$$(1, 0), \quad (0, 1), \quad \left(\frac{-1+\sqrt{7}}{4}, \frac{-1-\sqrt{7}}{4}\right), \quad \left(-\frac{\sqrt{7}}{4}, -\frac{3}{4}\right), \quad \left(-\frac{3}{4}, \frac{\sqrt{7}}{4}\right)$$

sum to 0, and their partial sums $0, (1, 0), (1, 1), (\frac{3+\sqrt{7}}{4}, \frac{3-\sqrt{7}}{4}), (\frac{3}{4}, -\frac{\sqrt{7}}{4})$ are distinct, so $G(\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{7}))$ contains a 5-cycle; as $7 \equiv 1 \pmod{3}$, $\sqrt{7} \in \mathbb{Q}_3$ and $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_3^2) \geq 3$. Finally $11 \equiv 2^2 \pmod{7}$, so $\sqrt{11} \in \mathbb{Q}_7$, and the 76-vertex unit-distance graph over $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{11})$ of [11] has no proper 3-colouring (a DRAT proof checked by `drat-trim` and by the verified checker `cake_lpr`, and a proof in Lean); so $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_7^2) \geq 4$. $\square$

Proof of Theorem 5. Let

$$\mathcal{D} = \{11, 23, 35, 47, 59, 71, 95, 119, 131, 155, 179, 191, 239, 251, \\ 263, 359, 431, 443, 455, 491, 599, 611, 791, 851, 911, 935, 959\}.$$

For each $d \in \mathcal{D}$, [11] gives a unit-distance graph over $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{d})$ with no proper 3-colouring. A segmented sieve with Jacobi symbols (`padic_reach.c` in [10], about half a minute) shows that for every prime $p \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$ with $7 \leq p < 2\,129\,503\,819$ some $d \in \mathcal{D}$ is a nonzero square modulo p , so $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{d}) \subset \mathbb{Q}_p$ and $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_p^2) \geq 4$; a separate script checks every prime below 10^7 again with Euler's criterion. The prime $2\,129\,503\,819$ is the first after 3 at which every $d \in \mathcal{D}$ is a non-square. For $p = 83$, the numbers 3, 11 and 247 are squares modulo 83, and [10] contains a 5-chromatic unit-distance graph over $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{3}, \sqrt{11}, \sqrt{247})$. $\square$

Proof of Proposition 6. Let M be the Galois closure of the compositum of $\mathbb{Q}(i)$ and the fields in $\mathcal{K}$, $G = \text{Gal}(M/\mathbb{Q})$, $D \subset G$ the decomposition group of a prime of M above 3, $I \subset D$ its inertia group, and $\sigma \in D$ an element mapping to the Frobenius generator of D/I , so that $D = \langle \sigma \rangle I$. By Chebotarev's theorem infinitely many primes p , unramified in M , have Frobenius conjugate to σ . Since 3 is inert in $\mathbb{Q}(i)$, σ acts on the residue field $\mathbb{F}_9$ of $\mathbb{Q}(i)$ at 3 by $x \mapsto x^3$ and so moves i ; hence $p \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$. Suppose $K = M^H \in \mathcal{K}$ embeds in $\mathbb{Q}_p$. Then a prime of K above p has residue degree 1, so the Frobenius at p , and with it σ , which has the same cycle type on G/H , fixes a coset gH ; and $D \cdot gH = I\langle \sigma \rangle \cdot gH = I \cdot gH$. The primes of K above 3 correspond to the D -orbits on G/H , with residue degree the number of I -orbits in the orbit (see [19, Chapter I, §9]); so the prime given by $D \cdot gH$ has residue field $\mathbb{F}_3$, in which -1 is not a square. The argument of Lemma 7 and Proposition 8, with a uniformiser in place of p and $\kappa(a, b) = a + b \pmod{3}$, then gives $\chi(K^2) \leq 3$, a contradiction. $\square$

For quadratic fields this is Fischer's theorem that $\chi(\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{N})^2) \leq 3$ when $N \equiv 0, 1 \pmod{3}$ [9]. A uniform bound $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_p^2) \geq 4$ for all $p \geq 7$ would follow, for example, from $\chi(\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{q})^2) \geq 4$ for every prime $q \equiv 11 \pmod{12}$: by Dirichlet's theorem every prime $p \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$ has such a q with $q \equiv 1 \pmod{p}$, so that $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{q}) \subset \mathbb{Q}_p$.

5. THE ISOTROPIC CASE

Proof of Proposition 3. Let $HG(F)$ be the graph on F^2 in which (x, y) and (x', y') are adjacent when $(x - x')(y - y') = 1$. By [3, Lemma 2.7], $HG(F)$ is an induced subgraph of the graph of any isotropic form over F , and it contains $HG(\mathbb{Q})$. The map $(x, y) \mapsto (x - y, x + y)$ sends the graph of $x^2 - y^2$ on $\mathbb{Q}^2$ onto $HG(\mathbb{Q})$, because $(\Delta x)^2 - (\Delta y)^2 = (\Delta x - \Delta y)(\Delta x + \Delta y)$. Davies

[6, Theorem 3], from a theorem of Graham, proved that every finite colouring of $\mathbb{Q}^2$ has a monochromatic pair with $(x - x')^2 - (y - y')^2 = 1$. Hence no finite colouring is proper. The form $x^2 + y^2$ is isotropic over F exactly when -1 is a square in F , and over $\mathbb{Q}_p$ this happens exactly when $p \equiv 1 \pmod{4}$. $\square$

Madore had observed that $\chi(\mathbb{R}^{1,1}) = \infty$ would give $\chi(\mathbb{C}^2) = \infty$ [13, ¶6.4], and Davies recorded this consequence of his theorem; the proposition is the same remark for any field of characteristic 0.

6. LINES AND HIGHER DIMENSIONS

For $n \geq 1$ let $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_p^n)$ be the chromatic number of the graph on $\mathbb{Q}_p^n$ joining v and w when $\sum_i (v_i - w_i)^2 = 1$, and $\chi_B(\mathbb{Q}_p^n)$, $\chi_m(\mathbb{Q}_p^n)$ its Borel and measurable versions.

Proposition 11. *$\chi(\mathbb{Q}_p^n)$ is finite if and only if $n = 1$, or $n = 2$ and $p \not\equiv 1 \pmod{4}$, or $p = 2$ and $n \leq 4$. Moreover:*

- (1) $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_p^1) = 2$ for every p , while $\chi_B(\mathbb{Q}_2^1) = 2$ and $\chi_B(\mathbb{Q}_p^1) = \chi_m(\mathbb{Q}_p^1) = 3$ for odd p ;
- (2) $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_2^2) = \chi(\mathbb{Q}_2^3) = 2$ and $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_2^4) = 4$, and the Borel chromatic numbers are the same.

Proof. Over $\mathbb{Q}_p$ every form in at least five variables is isotropic [20, Chapter IV, Theorem 6], and so is $x_1^2 + x_2^2 + x_3^2$ for odd p : it has a nonsingular zero modulo p by the Chevalley–Warning theorem, which lifts by Hensel’s lemma. For $p = 2$ the forms $x_1^2 + \dots + x_n^2$ with $n \leq 4$ are anisotropic: a primitive zero $(a_1, \dots, a_4) \in \mathbb{Z}_2^4$ would have $t \geq 1$ odd entries with $t \equiv \sum_i a_i^2 \equiv 0 \pmod{4}$, so $t = 4$, and then $\sum_i a_i^2 \equiv 4 \pmod{8}$. Proposition 3 gives $\chi = \infty$ in the isotropic cases, and Corollary 4 treats $n = 2$.

(1) The neighbours of x are $x \pm 1$, so each coset of $\mathbb{Z}$ in $\mathbb{Q}_p$ is a two-way infinite path, and colouring it by the parity of the offset from a chosen representative gives $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_p^1) = 2$. For a Borel colouring use the cosets of $\mathbb{Z}_p$ instead: $x \mapsto (x - r(x)) \bmod p$, with r as in the proof of Proposition 8, maps the graph to the cycle $\mathbb{Z}/p$ with steps ± 1 , which needs 2 colours for $p = 2$ and 3 for odd p . Conversely, for odd p a measurable 2-colouring c would satisfy $c(x + 2) = c(x)$; since 2 generates a dense subgroup of $\mathbb{Z}_p$, the translation by 2 is ergodic on $\mathbb{Z}_p$, so c would be almost everywhere constant on $\mathbb{Z}_p$, which contradicts $c(x + 1) \neq c(x)$.

(2) The graph has edges, and $0, (1, 0, 0, 0), (\frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{2}), (\frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{2}, -\frac{1}{2})$ are pairwise at distance 1, so $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_2^4) \geq 4$. For $n \leq 3$, if $\sum_i x_i^2 = 1$ with $\min_i v_2(x_i) = -k < 0$, then $\sum_i a_i^2 = 4^k$ with $a_i = 2^k x_i \in \mathbb{Z}_2$ not all even; but a sum of at most three squares of which $t \geq 1$ are odd is $\equiv t \not\equiv 0 \pmod{4}$. So unit vectors are integral, and as $\sum_i x_i^2 \equiv 1 \pmod{8}$ exactly one coordinate is odd; colouring each coset of $\mathbb{Z}_2^n$ by the parity of the coordinate sum (after subtracting its representative) gives $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_2^n) = 2$ for $n = 2, 3$. For $n = 4$ identify $\mathbb{Q}_2^4$ with Hamilton’s quaternions H over $\mathbb{Q}_2$ by $x \mapsto x_1 + x_2 i + x_3 j + x_4 k$, so that the form becomes the reduced norm N . As N is anisotropic, H is a division algebra; its valuation ring $\mathcal{O}_H = \{x : Nx \in \mathbb{Z}_2\}$ (the 2-adic Hurwitz order, $\mathbb{Z}_2^4 \cup (h + \mathbb{Z}_2^4)$ with $h = (\frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{2}, \frac{1}{2})$) has the maximal ideal $P = \{x : Nx \in 2\mathbb{Z}_2\} = \{x \in \mathbb{Z}_2^4 : \sum_i x_i \in 2\mathbb{Z}_2\}$ and the residue field $\mathcal{O}_H/P \cong \mathbb{F}_4$ [23, Proposition 13.3.4 and Theorem 13.3.11]. A unit vector lies in $\mathcal{O}_H \setminus P$, so adjacent points lie in one coset of $\mathcal{O}_H$ and their difference is nonzero in $\mathcal{O}_H/P$; fixing a representative $r(v)$ of each coset (the cosets are open) and colouring v by $(v - r(v)) \bmod P \in \mathbb{F}_4$ gives $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_2^4) \leq 4$. All these colourings are locally constant. $\square$

The values for $n = 3, 4$ are the 2-adic forms of Benda and Perles’s $\chi(\mathbb{Q}^3) = 2$ and $\chi(\mathbb{Q}^4) = 4$ [1], as cited in [13, ¶1.6] (see also [21, §§11.3–11.4]); we have not read their proofs. Since $\mathbb{Q}^n \subset \mathbb{Q}_2^n$ and the tetrahedron above is rational, the proposition proves both values again. By Corollary 4, and in one variable because the graph of ax^2 is empty or is $x \sim x \pm b$, which $x \mapsto x/b$ turns into $x \sim x \pm 1$ with a Borel colouring in at most three colours (through the residue field as in (1), or by $\lfloor \text{Re } x \rfloor \bmod 2$ over $\mathbb{R}$ and $\mathbb{C}$), a non-degenerate quadratic graph over a local field of characteristic 0 never has finite chromatic number and infinite Borel chromatic number, the behaviour that [3, Remark 1.3] asks about; on the p -adic line with p odd the two differ by one, as for the graphs of irrational rotations.

7. QUESTIONS

- (1) For $p \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$, $\chi_B(\mathbb{Q}_p^2) \rightarrow \infty$, but the ordinary $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_p^2)$ is only known to be at least 4 for $7 \leq p < 2\,129\,503\,819$ (Theorem 5) and at least 5 at $p = 83$. Is it bounded? A finite subgraph whose coordinates generate a field with a real embedding lies in $\mathbb{R}^2$, so more than seven colours would need a field with no real embedding. If $\chi(K^2)$ is unbounded over number fields K in which -1 is not a square, then so is $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_p^2)$ over $p \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$, since by Chebotarev's theorem each such K embeds in $\mathbb{Q}_p$ for infinitely many $p \equiv 3 \pmod{4}$. If $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_p^2)$ is bounded, the p -adic planes are a quantitative analogue, along a family, of the gap between ordinary and Borel chromatic numbers that [3, Remark 1.3] asks about (whose own instance, for indefinite real forms, is ruled out by Davies's theorem).
- (2) Is $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_{11}^2)$ equal to 4 or 5? Since 47, 3 and 5 are squares modulo 11, the field $\mathbb{Q}_{11}$ contains $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{47})$ and $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{3}, \sqrt{5})$; so $\chi(\mathbb{Q}_{11}^2) = 4$ would give $\chi(\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{47})^2) = 4$, a case Moorhouse asked about [18] that is still open [11], and $\chi(\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{3}, \sqrt{5})^2) \leq 4$. The colourings of $\mathbb{Q}_{11}^2$ that are constant on the cosets of $11^k \mathbb{Z}_{11}^2$ need five colours for $k = 1, 2, 3$ [10]. At $p = 19$ the question about $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{47})$ is the same, as $47 \equiv 3^2 \pmod{19}$, but $\mathbb{Q}(\sqrt{3}, \sqrt{5})$ does not embed in $\mathbb{Q}_{19}$; there we only know that the colourings constant on the cosets of $19\mathbb{Z}_{19}^2$ need five colours.
- (3) How fast does $\chi_B(\mathbb{Q}_p^2)$ grow? Theorem 1 places it between $(\frac{1}{2} + o(1))\sqrt{p}$ and $(p + 1)/2$.

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